

Monica Agarwal

Last updated: April, 2026

[Click here for the most recent version](#)

Institute for Policy Research, Northwestern University
2040 Sheridan Rd, Evanston, IL 60208

✉ monica.agarwal@northwestern.edu
🌐 <https://monica-agarwal.github.io>

RESEARCH INTERESTS

Development Economics, Economics of Education, Applied Microeconomics

ACADEMIC APPOINTMENTS

2024–	Postdoctoral Fellow, Institute for Policy Research, Northwestern University
-------	---

EDUCATION

2024	Ph.D., Agricultural & Applied Economics, University of Wisconsin–Madison Dissertation: <i>"Essays in Development Economics"</i> Outstanding Dissertation Award , University of Wisconsin–Madison
2020	M.S., Agricultural & Applied Economics, University of Wisconsin–Madison
2018	M.Phil., Economics, Jawaharlal Nehru University, India
2014	M.A., Economics, Jadavpur University, India
2012	B.A. (Hons.), Economics, Jadavpur University, India

REFERENCES

Prof. Laura Schechter (<i>PhD Advisor</i>) Department of Economics University of Wisconsin-Madison ✉ lschechter@wisc.edu	Prof. Jeffrey A. Smith Department of Economics University of Wisconsin-Madison ✉ econjeff@ssc.wisc.edu
--	--

Prof. Priya Mukherjee Department of Agricultural and Applied Economics University of Wisconsin-Madison ✉ priya.mukherjee@wisc.edu	Prof. Diane Whitmore Schanzenbach McCourt School of Public Policy Georgetown University ✉ diane.schanzenbach@georgetown.edu
--	---

WORKING PAPERS

-
- Affirmative Action at School Entry: School Quality and Learning. [JMP] [\[SSRN\]](#) (Under Review)
 - The Unintended Benefits of Women's Empowerment on Household Sanitation (with [Md Moshi Ul Alam](#)). [\[SSRN\]](#) *R&R, Journal of Human Resources* (resubmitted)
 - Parental Investments and Sibling Spillover Effects of Affirmative Action Policies: Evidence from India. [Draft available upon request.]

SELECTED RESEARCH IN PROGRESS

-
- Spatial Inequality and School Choice Mechanisms (with [Md Moshi Ul Alam](#), [Chao Fu](#), [YingHua He](#))
 - The Impact of Chicago's Universal Pre-K Expansion on Children's Test Scores (with [Diane W. Schanzenbach](#))
 - The Early Childhood Care and Education Workforce (with [Diane W. Schanzenbach](#))

POLICY WRITING

- [“The Shifting Demographics of Chicago’s Young Children”](#), with John Q. Easton, Arthur Raines, Terri Sabol and Diane W. Schanzenbach. Institute for Policy Research, May 2025.

ACADEMIC AWARDS, RESEARCH GRANTS, AND FUNDING

2024 AAE Outstanding Dissertation Award, University of Wisconsin–Madison
 2021 J-PAL Post Primary Education Initiative (USD 10,000)
 2021 Dissertation Research Grant, AAE, UW–Madison (USD 1,000)
 2018 AAE Student Research Travel Grant, UW–Madison
 2018 Graduate School Research Travel Grant (Conference), UW–Madison
 2016–2018 UGC India Non-NET Fellowship

REFEREEING SERVICE

Journal of Development Economics, Economics of Education Review (x2), World Bank Economic Review

RESEARCH ASSISTANCE

2022–24 Prof. Jessica Pac, Department of Social Work, UW–Madison
 2021–22 Prof. Bradford Barham, AAE, UW–Madison
 2020–21 Prof. Laura Schechter, AAE, UW–Madison
 2019–20 Prof. Emilia Tjernström, AAE, UW–Madison
 2018–19 Prof. Bradford Barham, AAE, UW–Madison

TEACHING

2020 Spring — AAE 215: Introduction to Agricultural and Applied Economics (TA for Prof. Eduardo Cenci)
Average rating: 4.8/5

OTHER SERVICE

Organizer, Development Lab, Department of Agricultural and Applied Economics, UW–Madison (2022–2023)

CONFERENCES & SEMINARS

2025: Water Supply, Sanitation and Hygiene 2025 (WASH 2025), Clark University, APPAM
 2024: Northeastern Universities Development Consortium (NEUDC 2024), Indian Statistical Institute-Delhi
 2019–2023: AAE Development Lab; Development Economics Workshop; Student Research Colloquium (UW–Madison)
 2023: AMIE; University of Georgia AAE Graduate Development Workshop
 2018: 14th Annual Conference on Growth & Development, Indian Statistical Institute-Delhi

AFFILIATIONS

2024– Institute for Policy Research, Northwestern University

2024– Early Childhood Research Alliance of Chicago, Northwestern University

2022–2023 Association for Mentoring and Inclusion in Economics (AMIE)

2019 Graduate Research Fellow, Institute for Research on Poverty, UW–Madison

PRIOR EMPLOYMENT

2014–2016 — Associate Consultant, *Big Data Analytics*, Wipro Limited, India

OTHER INFORMATION

Languages: English (fluent), Hindi (native), Bengali (fluent)

Citizenship: India

Permanent Residency: Canada